the finalised text of the Persian agreement was circulated through the War Cabinet for approval, Curzon justified the agreement by arguing that ‘if Persia were to be left alone, there is every reason to fear that she would soon be overrun by Bolshevik influences from the north’.[102]

*The idea of an imminent threat of a Bolshevik takeover of Persia was also reflected in many British newspapers that reported on the agreement. The Times believed that the Bolshevik regime was at that very moment ‘preparing a war of conquest in Persian territory’,[103] while The Daily Telegraph argued that there was every reason to believe that if Britain refused to help Persia, ‘that in a very short time the whole country would be overrun by Bolshevik agents’.[104] The Manchester Guardian ominously noted that, for Persia, ‘there are always the Bolsheviks looming on the horizon, and it is impossible to say...what engines of war of the most “modern type” may not be needed in order to counteract the inflow, if not of Bolshevik arms, yet of the more deadly Bolshevik doctrine’.[105] How far Curzon was really fearful of a Bolshevik incursion into Persia, and how far it was a convenient way to justify his expansionist ambitions is questionable.[106]*

*Whatever Curzon’s real motivations, for all this anti-Bolshevik rhetoric, it was to be the White Russian element that was to be the most immediate threat to Britain’s interests in Persia in late 1919. The Bolsheviks of course immediately denounced the agreement as ‘a scrap of paper’, refusing to recognise its legitimacy, but offered no real help to the Persians. Those Russians who ran the legation and Cossack Division, however, were able to cause much more trouble for the British. For the officials of the former tsarist regime, the agreement not only represented the strengthening of Britain’s presence in Persia, but an extension of that influence into ostensibly ‘Russian’ territory. For the Cossack Division, the concept of a uniform force, with British rather than Russian officers in command, obviously constituted a great threat to its position in Persia. On 29 August 1919, Cox was asked outright by the Russian minister whether the agreement marked a change in Britain’s policy towards Russian interests in north Persia. While Cox replied in the negative, this did little to reassure Russian officials.[107] On 1 September, it was reported by Cox that Minorskii, together with Staroselskii, had been in close communication with M. Bonin*